



GAZIANTEP TURKEY

Fresh-Baked Baklava in Turkey

Gaziantep, gateway to southeastern Anatolia, claims to be the historic homeland of Turkey's most famous pastry. Among the evocative ruins of past powers, bazaars, and museums, nearly 200 pastry shops compete to bake the best version of baklava – and with excellent restaurants and coffee and tea houses, too, Gaziantep has become something of a culinary capital.



Capital of Turkey's Gaziantep province and the country's sixth-largest city, Gaziantep is also one of the oldest continuously inhabited towns in the world. Lying on a valuable caravan route connecting Mesopotamia, Egypt, and Anatolia, the town saw many powers, including the Assyrians, Babylonians, Persians, Greeks, and Romans pass through its portals. The ghosts of these transient rulers can sometimes be felt in the evocative and melancholy old ruins that dot the modern city.

Gaziantep is an important center of traditional and modern industry. Around the town, coppersmiths can be seen, smelled, and above all heard as they hammer away at glinting pots and pans. But this is also one of Turkey's most productive agricultural regions, and Gaziantep is the epicenter of the region's famous *fıstık* (pistachio) cultivation, the fundamental ingredient for the town's famous pastry, baklava. A local saying has it that you are never more than five minutes' walk from one of the town's innumerable pastry shops, and both Turkish and foreign tourists alike flock to the town to satisfy a sweet tooth and a growling stomach.

The baklava, with its countless layers of crisp filo pastry filled with chopped nuts that ooze syrup or

honey, is found all over Turkey. The word "baklava" may stem from a Mongolian-Turkic word meaning "to pile up," and local tradition has it that the pastry was developed in the imperial kitchens of the Topkapı Palace in Istanbul as a way of pleasing and placating the Sultan. The dessert later became fashionable throughout the Ottoman empire. Gaziantep's acclaimed version is always made with pistachios and is judged to be the best not just in Turkey, but in the world.

The city's top baklava chefs claim the secret lies in selecting the finest and freshest local ingredients: carefully sourced and organically grown pistachio nuts, olive oil, and honey. Gaziantep's soil is believed to infuse the ingredients with a special flavor and aroma, and its top chefs use pastry skills and recipes often closely guarded within a family for generations.

According to local connoisseurs, the perfect pastry should be light in the hand, sweet (but not overly syrupy) in the mouth, and, above all, crisp to the bite. A Gaziantep baklava fresh out of the oven, served with a cup of thick, dark Turkish coffee, is an eating experience never forgotten. It's no wonder that so many visitors to Gaziantep come away with a copper Turkish coffee pot tucked under one arm and a box of baklava under the other.

A Day in Gaziantep

Most of the sights, pastry shops, cafés, and restaurants can be found within strolling distance of the square still popularly known as *Hükümet Konağı* (Government House).

MORNING Climb up to the Roman-built, Seljuk-restored **Kale** (citadel) for a great view of the city. Then visit the **bazaar**, where you can wander the stands, alleyways, and workshops and shop for pistachios. Stop for coffee and baklava at **Tahmis kahvehane** (coffeehouse) or **Tütün Hanı** teahouse, set in an atmospheric former caravanserai – a fortified inn built to protect and house travelers on the Silk Road.

AFTERNOON Head for the **Gaziantep Museum** and the **Zeugma Kültür ve Müze Merkezi** on İstasyon Caddesi, with its stunning collection of Roman mosaics. Picnic in the lovely **100 Yıl Atatürk Kültür Parkı**, then explore the **Hasan Süzer Ethnography Museum** just off Atatürk Caddesi, in a 200-year-old traditional Gaziantep house.

EVENING Take in the 19th-century **Kurtuluş Camii** mosque and the **Alaüddevle Camii**, near the coppersmith market, where you can pick up that copper coffee pot.

Essentials

GETTING THERE

Domestic flights from Istanbul serve **Oguzeli Airport**, a short **taxi** or **bus** ride from downtown.

WHERE TO STAY

Has Hotel (inexpensive) is centrally located, with plain but well-furnished, spotless rooms. *email: info@hotelhas.com*
Anadolu Evleri (moderate) is a traditional stone house near the bazaar. *www.anadoluevleri.com*
Dayı Ahmet Ağa Konağı (moderate–expensive) offers central, boutique-style rooms in a *konak* (mansion). *www.dayiahmetagakonagi.com*

TOURIST INFORMATION

100 Yıl Atatürk Kültür Parkı; +90 342 230 5969

